

Burbank airport collision risk is a concern

In unusual remarks, national safety board chair says ‘people are raising red flags.’

By Andrew J. Campa, Richard Winton and Grace Toohey

The chair of the National Transportation Safety Board called out Hollywood Burbank Airport as having a concerning risk of a midair collision and urged federal regulators to take action.

NTSB Chair Jennifer Homendy, speaking at a board meeting in Washington, said commercial airlines had warned of the risk of aircraft colliding at Burbank Airport. The airport is a busy Class C, or medium-sized, airport with short runways and a tight airspace. It is among “hotspots” with a high volume of mixed helicopter and airplane traffic, according to the FAA.

“Burbank is one where commercial airlines have called me to say the next midair is going to be at Burbank, and nobody at [the Federal Aviation Administration] is paying attention to us,” Homendy said.

She added that “whether it is involving helicopters or not, people are raising red flags, and why aren’t people listening? The FAA has to ensure safety. That is their job.”

Homendy spoke just before the first anniversary of a catastrophic crash that claimed 67 lives outside Washington, D.C. The agency revealed findings into the crash of an American Airlines regional jet and an Army Black Hawk helicopter.

As Homendy laid out what she called a series of institutional failures by the FAA before the January 2025 crash, she pointed to concerns about the mixing of commercial airplane and helicopter traffic, noting that there are extensive data pointing to the danger of [See **Airport**, A7]



THE MINARET Mountains with Mammoth ski resort in the foreground.

Deaths of ski patrollers raise safety questions

Some blame fatalities on pressure to open slopes quickly after storms, a claim Mammoth disputes

By Jack Dolan

After an enormous storm dumped 3 feet of snow on Mammoth Mountain, rookie ski patroller Claire Murphy and a partner scrambled to help make the resort safe for guests ahead of a very busy — and very lucrative — Presidents Day weekend.

In howling wind and blowing snow, the patrollers labored to clear enormous piles of fresh, unstable powder from a steep, experts-only run, one of a group appropriately named the “Avalanche Chutes.”

Ski patrollers use hand-held explosives, and their own skis, to deliberately trigger small slides in the chutes before the resort opens, to prevent an avalanche from crashing down later in the day on thousands of paying customers gliding happily — and obliviously — along the much gentler slopes below.



LISA APA



TRACY MURPHY

CLAIRE Murphy, top, and Cole Murphy (no relation) died during avalanche mitigation work.

But something went horribly wrong that day. Instead of remaining safely above the sliding snow, Murphy and her partner got caught in it. He was buried up to his neck but survived. She was trapped beneath the collapsing wall of white and got crushed to death against a towering fir tree. She was 25 years old.

The avalanche that killed the young patroller on Feb. 14, 2025, stunned Mammoth’s tight-knit ski community. Her friends and colleagues were consumed with grief, but most regarded it as a freak accident, something that hadn’t happened before and was unlikely to be repeated.

But then, less than a year later, it happened again.

In late December — after a “Christmas miracle” storm [See **Mammoth**, A6]

Amid furor over shooting, GOP softens its tone

Effort to de-escalate after Minneapolis killing has not brought policy changes so far.

By Jenny Jarvie and Andrea Castillo

MINNEAPOLIS — Key Republicans in the Trump administration are retreating from their blanket defense of Border Patrol agents who fatally shot a U.S. citizen Saturday on a Minneapolis street, part of a larger effort by the White House to turn down the temperature after the killing provoked widespread outrage.

But it remains unclear whether the tamping down of Republican rhetoric is just damage control after the shooting, or whether it will usher in a more fundamental scaling back of President Trump’s hard-line immigration crackdown in American cities from Los Angeles to Chicago.

In Minneapolis, there were few signs of a reduction in force on the streets, where tensions have been high since the shooting.

On Wednesday morning, protesters gathered outside the federal Whipple Building, the epicenter of immigration activity in the city, as a steady stream of federal agents entered and exited.

“Traitor!” one woman yelled out to a car driven by masked agents.

“Murderers!” a man said.

As Richi Mead, dressed in a neon vest that labeled him as a peaceful observer (“DON’T SHOOT”), tracked federal vehicles coming in and out, he said he did not believe there had been a reduction in the number of federal immigration agents in his city. The rate of cars he saw Wednesday, he said, was “business as usual.”

“They’ve entrenched themselves here,” he said of federal agents. “There’s no end to this — and there’s no end to Minnesotans showing up.”

As a growing number of Republicans have joined Democrats to protest Alex Pretti’s killing and Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem faces increasing criticism, Trump has expressed a desire to “de-escalate a little bit.” [See **Shooting**, A5]



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

OFFICIALS initially defended the agents who fatally shot Alex Pretti. Above, a memorial in Minneapolis.

Newsom a firm no on scrapping ICE

The governor has repeatedly rejected other Democrats’ calls to abolish the agency.

By Michael Wilner

WASHINGTON — It took Democrats nearly a year to respond with a unified message to President Trump’s signature policy initiative, harnessing national outrage over the administration’s immigration enforcement tactics in Minnesota this week to leverage government funding and demand change.

Yet divisions persist as the party barrels toward midterm elections and, a year from now, the start of primary season. And Gavin Newsom stands right in the middle of them.

A calibrated position by the California governor has placed him to the right of the party’s progressive base that has opposed the very existence of U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement for years — well before Republican lawmakers passed legislation doubling the agency’s budget, in-

creasing its presence and visibility in American life.

Newsom has rejected calls for ICE to be abolished since the 2024 campaign, when Democrats saw clear alarms in public polling that showed President Biden and his vice president, Kamala Harris, on the back foot against Trump on immigration. To the contrary, Newsom has highlighted California’s cooperation with the agency, and his efforts to protect that relationship from progressive local lawmakers.

Although Trump’s federalization of the California National Guard last summer was prompted, in part, by protests in Los Angeles against ICE raids across the city, the governor’s reaction focused more on the president’s alleged abuses of power than on the ICE raids themselves. To the extent he did comment on them, Newsom [See **Newsom**, A5]

ICE votes at issue in governor race

Democrats vying to lead the state accuse one another of supporting funding. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

‘Finally, a renter’s market’ in L.A. area

Prices in December hit a four-year low. But they’re steady or rising in other places.

By Jack Flemming

Sandra Gomez braced for impact as she opened the lease renewal offer for her East Los Angeles apartment in September. She had been paying \$2,000 for the last 12 months, but since the unit wasn’t covered by L.A.’s Rent Stabilization Ordinance, her landlord could jack up the price for the next lease.

The new price? \$1,950.

“I thought it was a mistake,” Gomez said. “Since when does rent get cheaper in L.A.?”

For years, L.A. has been one of the costliest cities in the country for renters. Annual price hikes seemed inevitable, and finding the perfect apartment felt more like a competitive sport.

But data suggest that the market could be ever so slightly shifting.

The median rent in the

L.A. metro area dropped to \$2,167 in December — the lowest price in four years, according to data from Apartment List that analyze new leases for one- and two-bedroom apartments in a given month. The median rent for L.A. County also dropped to a four-year low, \$2,035.

The last time L.A. rents were that low was January 2022, in the wake of a furious pandemic home-buying market that saw a wave of renters buy homes for the first time, leaving apartments empty and bringing prices down.

The drop-off mirrors a national trend, as the U.S. median rent dropped to a similar four-year low in December. But within Southern California, the downturn is unique to L.A. County. Over the same stretch, rents rose or remained steady in Orange, Ventura and San Bernardino counties and in California as a whole.

Experts disagree on the extent of the drop; some say it’s a sign of things to come, while others suggest it’s merely a brief price plateau and rents will rise again this [See **Rents**, A7]

Rubio defends Trump’s Venezuela policy

By Gavin J. Quinton

WASHINGTON — Secretary of State Marco Rubio left the door open Wednesday to future U.S. military action in Venezuela, telling lawmakers that while the Trump administration does not anticipate further escalation, the president retains the authority to use force if Venezuela’s interim leadership or other American adversaries defy U.S. demands.

Rubio’s remarks came hours after President Trump deployed what he called a “massive armada” to pressure Iran back to the negotiating table over its nuclear weapons program, amid broader questions about how recent U.S. tensions with Denmark over Greenland are affecting American relations with NATO allies.



J. SCOTT APPLEWHITE Associated Press

SECRETARY of State Marco Rubio appears before the Senate Foreign Relations Committee to testify.

“The president never rules out his options as commander in chief to protect the national interest of the United States,” Rubio told the Senate Foreign Relations Committee. “I can tell you right now with full certainty, we are not postured to, nor do we intend or expect to take any military action in Venezuela at any time.”

The appearance marked [See **Rubio**, A5]

LAFD nonprofit paid \$65,000 for PR
Foundation addresses the controversy over funds used for Palisades fire messaging. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Clippers, Lakers consider options
Local teams are unlikely to make big moves at deadline but could add role players. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather
Mostly sunny; warm. L.A. Basin: 83/56. **B6**

Markets A11
Opinion Voices A12

Georgia election site is searched
The FBI targets office central to right-wing theories about Trump’s 2020 loss. **NATION, A4**

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